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Immigration and Redistribution

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Does immigration change support for redistribution, and which perceptions of immigrants matter most for that change?
- **Setting.** The paper runs large online surveys and experiments on roughly 24,000 non-immigrant respondents in six countries: France, Germany, Italy, Sweden, the United Kingdom, and the United States.
- **Core empirical object.** The paper measures respondents' perceptions of immigrants' share, origins, religion, education, employment, poverty, work effort, welfare use, and fiscal contribution.
- **Main misperception fact.** Respondents greatly overestimate the number of immigrants. For example, in the U.S. the actual documented immigrant share is about 10%, while the average perceived share is about 36%; in Italy the true share is about 10%, while the perceived share is about 26%.
- **Composition misperceptions.** Respondents also believe that immigrants are more culturally distant and economically weaker than they are: more Muslim, less Christian, less educated, more unemployed, poorer, and more likely to benefit from redistribution.
- **Robustness of misperceptions.** Misperceptions are not just survey inattentiveness. They remain when respondents are incentivized for accuracy and when immigrant perceptions are benchmarked against perceptions about non-immigrants.
- **Main treatment result.** Simply making respondents think about immigration before asking about redistribution reduces support for redistribution. This effect appears in policy questions and in actual charitable donation choices.
- **Most important mechanism.** Perceptions that immigrants are economically weak and likely to benefit from or free-ride on the welfare state are more strongly related to redistribution preferences than perceptions of immigrant share or cultural distance.
- **Information treatments.** Information about the true share and origins of immigrants changes some perceptions, but generally has limited ability to raise support for redistribution. A hard-working immigrant narrative moves some beliefs more, but does not fully undo the negative immigration salience effect.
- **Takeaway.** People's beliefs about immigrants—especially economic and welfare-use beliefs—shape redistribution preferences. Narratives may be more powerful than factual corrections in changing these beliefs.

2 Incremental contribution of the paper

2.1 Contribution relative to the immigration-and-welfare-state literature

- Prior work studied whether ethnic diversity and immigration reduce redistribution, but often relied on aggregate data, voting outcomes, or broad correlations between immigration and welfare-state size.
- This paper moves to individual-level perceptions and experiments. It asks not only whether immigration affects redistribution preferences, but also *which beliefs about immigrants* drive the effect.
- The paper separates misperceptions about immigrant quantity from misperceptions about immigrant composition: origins, religion, education, poverty, unemployment, work effort, and fiscal behaviour.

Interpretation: The incremental step is from a macro “diversity reduces redistribution” claim to a micro mechanism: people reduce redistribution support when they view immigrants as economically weak, undeserving, or welfare dependent.

2.2 Contribution relative to the misperceptions literature

- Earlier work documents misperceptions about income inequality, tax burdens, mobility, and government spending.
- This paper documents a parallel and highly systematic set of misperceptions about immigrants across six developed countries.
- It benchmarks immigrant misperceptions against non-immigrant misperceptions, showing that respondents are not merely generally inaccurate: they are particularly inaccurate about immigrants.
- It uses monetary incentives and willingness-to-pay for information to distinguish lack of knowledge from lack of attention or effort.

Interpretation: The paper’s contribution is not just “people are wrong.” It shows that the wrong beliefs are directional, politically relevant, and linked to policy preferences.

2.3 Contribution relative to information-treatment experiments

- The paper compares hard numerical facts, information about origins, and a narrative about a hard-working immigrant.
- It shows that factual information changes some first-stage perceptions but has weak downstream effects on redistribution support.
- The narrative treatment has stronger effects on beliefs about work effort but still cannot fully offset the negative effect of immigration salience.

Interpretation: The paper advances the information-treatment literature by showing that correcting facts is not enough when narratives and deeper stereotypes shape policy views.

2.4 Contribution relative to survey-experimental methods

- The experiment uses a large cross-country sample with nationally representative quotas.
- It combines perception elicitation, randomized information treatments, order/salience treatments, real-stakes charitable donation choices, and willingness-to-pay for information.
- The design distinguishes perceptions, attitudes toward immigration, redistribution preferences, and actual pro-redistribution behaviour.

Interpretation: The paper’s research design is unusually rich: it does not only ask for stated support for redistribution but also observes behaviour through the donation choice.

3 Data and measurement

3.1 Countries, sample, and respondents

- The survey is conducted in six countries: France, Germany, Italy, Sweden, the UK, and the U.S.
- The main sample is approximately 24,000 non-immigrant respondents.
- Respondents are recruited by commercial survey companies and are sampled to be nationally representative along observable demographic dimensions.
- The paper defines immigrants using the OECD definition: legally resident people who were born abroad.

- The sample is restricted to non-immigrants because the object is how natives or non-immigrants perceive immigrants and how these perceptions affect redistribution preferences.

Interpretation: The cross-country setting is crucial because countries differ in welfare-state size, immigration history, and political debate. The same design across six countries helps isolate general mechanisms from country-specific politics.

3.2 The immigration block

The immigration block elicits perceptions about:

- the share of immigrants in the total population;
- the region of origin of immigrants;
- the religious composition of immigrants;
- education, unemployment, income, poverty, and welfare use of immigrants;
- work effort and deservingness of immigrants;
- attitudes toward immigration policy, citizenship, benefit eligibility, and whether immigration is a problem.

Interpretation: The block is designed to capture both quantitative beliefs and qualitative narratives: how many immigrants there are, who they are, and whether they are deserving.

3.3 The redistribution block

The redistribution block measures support for redistribution through:

- desired taxation of high incomes;
- desired taxation or transfers for the bottom 50%;
- desired allocation of government budgets toward social spending and education;
- whether inequality is viewed as a serious problem;
- a real-stakes donation choice to charities helping low-income people.

Interpretation: The donation measure is important because it moves beyond stated policy preferences and tests whether treatment effects translate into actual redistributive behaviour.

3.4 Misperception measures

For any perception variable k , the paper’s natural misperception object is:

$$Misperception_{i,k} = Perception_{i,k} - Truth_k. \quad (1)$$

For binary accuracy measures, the paper also uses indicators such as:

$$Accurate_i = \mathbf{1}\{|Perception_i - Truth| \leq 1\}, \quad (2)$$

where respondents are treated as accurate if their answer is within one percentage point of the true value.

Interpretation: The sign of the misperception matters. Overestimating immigrant share or welfare use can generate different policy attitudes from underestimating them.

3.5 Composite perception indices

The paper constructs indices for:

- perceived cultural distance;
- perceived economic weakness;
- perceived free-riding or welfare dependence;
- support for immigration;
- support for redistribution.

These indices are standardized and are often constructed following the Kling, Liebman, and Katz approach:

$$Index_i = \frac{1}{K} \sum_{k=1}^K \frac{Y_{i,k} - \mu_k}{\sigma_k}. \quad (3)$$

Interpretation: Indices reduce multiple-testing concerns and capture broad attitudes rather than isolated survey answers.

3.6 Accuracy incentives and willingness to pay

- Some respondents are randomly offered monetary incentives for accurate answers.
- At the end of the survey, some respondents can pay a randomized price to receive correct information about immigrants.
- The willingness-to-pay design measures demand for accurate information.

Interpretation: These design elements distinguish ignorance from careless answering and reveal that people with larger misperceptions are often less willing to learn the truth.

4 Experimental design and empirical specifications

4.1 Order or salience treatment

The paper randomizes whether respondents see the immigration block before or after the redistribution block. The main salience regression is:

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta Order_i + X_i' \gamma + \delta_c + \varepsilon_i, \quad (4)$$

where $Order_i = 1$ if the respondent is primed with immigration questions before redistribution questions, X_i contains respondent controls, and δ_c are country fixed effects.

Interpretation: The coefficient β measures whether making immigration salient reduces support for redistribution.

4.2 Video information treatments

Respondents are randomly assigned to one of three video treatments or control:

1. **Share of immigrants treatment:** informs respondents about the actual share of immigrants in their country and compares it with other countries.
2. **Origins of immigrants treatment:** informs respondents about where immigrants come from.
3. **Hard work treatment:** provides an anecdote about a hard-working immigrant and her daily schedule.

The generic treatment regression is:

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{ShareTreat}_i + \beta_2 \text{OriginsTreat}_i + \beta_3 \text{HardWorkTreat}_i + X_i' \gamma + \delta_c + \varepsilon_i. \quad (5)$$

Interpretation: The first two treatments are fact-based. The third treatment is narrative-based. Comparing them shows whether hard facts or stories are more effective in changing beliefs and policy preferences.

4.3 Correlations between perceptions and policy views

The paper estimates regressions of support for immigration or redistribution on perception measures:

$$\text{Support}_i = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{ShareMisperception}_i + \beta_2 \text{CulturalDistance}_i + \beta_3 \text{EconomicWeakness}_i + \beta_4 \text{FreeRiding}_i + X_i' \gamma + \delta_c + \varepsilon_i. \quad (6)$$

Interpretation: These regressions show which perceptions matter most for redistribution attitudes. The key result is that perceived economic weakness and welfare dependence are more strongly related to redistribution preferences than perceived immigrant share.

4.4 Local and national exposure regressions

To understand the origins of perceptions, the paper relates perceptions to actual immigrant shares and characteristics at the local or national level:

$$\text{Perception}_{i,r} = \alpha + \beta \text{ActualCharacteristic}_r + X_i' \gamma + \delta_c + \varepsilon_i. \quad (7)$$

Interpretation: If perceptions respond to actual local exposure, β should be positive. The paper finds some relationship, but actual variation explains only part of the misperceptions.

5 Identification and credibility

5.1 What is experimentally identified

- Randomized order identifies the causal effect of making immigration salient before redistribution questions.
- Randomized videos identify the causal effect of factual and narrative information on perceptions and policy preferences.
- The donation outcome tests whether treatment effects influence behaviour, not only stated attitudes.

Interpretation: The strongest causal claims are about treatment effects: priming immigration reduces redistribution support, while information videos have limited downstream effects.

5.2 What is associational

- The link between naturally held perceptions and redistribution support is partly correlational.
- People with anti-redistribution views may also choose or retain negative beliefs about immigrants.
- Local exposure regressions are not randomized and may reflect sorting, media environments, or political context.

Interpretation: The paper therefore uses the perception regressions as mechanism evidence, while relying on randomized treatments for causal effects.

5.3 Why the design is credible

- The survey covers six countries with different welfare states and immigration histories.
- The design compares immigrant perceptions to non-immigrant perceptions, reducing concerns that respondents simply do not understand all social statistics.
- Monetary incentives show that misperceptions do not disappear when accuracy is rewarded.
- Willingness-to-pay evidence shows that many respondents, especially those with large misperceptions, are not eager to obtain accurate information.

Interpretation: These features make it difficult to dismiss the findings as carelessness, confusion, or a single-country political artefact.

5.4 Limitations

- Online survey respondents may differ from the full population in unobserved ways.
- The paper focuses on legal immigrants, while some public debates combine legal and undocumented immigrants.
- Survey experiments measure short-run treatment effects; long-run belief updating may differ.
- The video treatments are specific interventions and may not capture the full range of political messaging.

Interpretation: The paper is strongest at identifying immediate effects of salience and information. It is less able to determine how durable the belief changes are.

6 Tables and figures

6.1 Table 1 and Figure 1: sample and perception elicitation

Read:

- Table 1 shows that each country’s sample is close to nationally representative along gender, age, income, marriage, employment, and education.
- Figure 1 shows the slider-and-pie-chart tool used to elicit perceived immigrant shares.
- The design avoids pure text entry and makes the population-share constraint visually salient.

Economic message: The elicitation interface matters because the paper studies misperceptions. The authors try to make respondents’ answers as meaningful and interpretable as possible.

TABLE 1
Sample characteristics

	US		UK		France		Italy		Germany		Sweden	
	Sample (1)	Pop (2)	Sample (3)	Pop (4)	Sample (5)	Pop (6)	Sample (7)	Pop (8)	Sample (9)	Pop (10)	Sample (11)	Pop (12)
Male	0.48	0.49	0.48	0.48	0.49	0.49	0.50	0.50	0.50	0.49	0.50	0.50
18–29 y.o.	0.24	0.24	0.24	0.26	0.23	0.23	0.19	0.19	0.23	0.22	0.22	0.24
30–39 y.o.	0.19	0.20	0.18	0.19	0.19	0.20	0.22	0.22	0.17	0.18	0.19	0.19
40–49 y.o.	0.19	0.19	0.22	0.21	0.22	0.21	0.24	0.23	0.20	0.20	0.20	0.21
50–59 y.o.	0.21	0.20	0.19	0.18	0.20	0.20	0.19	0.19	0.23	0.23	0.19	0.18
60–69 y.o.	0.18	0.17	0.17	0.16	0.16	0.15	0.16	0.17	0.16	0.17	0.19	0.18
Income bracket 1	0.16	0.16	0.30	0.31	0.30	0.32	0.28	0.27	0.25	0.26	0.33	0.33
Income bracket 2	0.19	0.19	0.35	0.35	0.31	0.30	0.29	0.28	0.29	0.29	0.28	0.29
Income bracket 3	0.22	0.22	0.12	0.11	0.14	0.14	0.20	0.19	0.23	0.23	0.22	0.22
Income bracket 4	0.43	0.43	0.24	0.23	0.25	0.24	0.23	0.26	0.22	0.22	0.17	0.17
Married	0.51	0.49	0.52	0.41	0.42	0.46	0.58	0.46	0.47	0.46	0.34	0.33
Employed	0.60	0.70	0.68	0.74	0.64	0.65	0.65	0.57	0.65	0.75	0.72	0.77
Unemployed	0.08	0.05	0.04	0.05	0.10	0.09	0.11	0.11	0.04	0.04	0.04	0.05
College	0.51	0.41	0.37	0.36	0.50	0.31	0.36	0.16	0.27	0.25	0.43	0.36

Notes: This table displays summary statistics for the main analysis sample (in odd columns) alongside nationally representative statistics (in even columns). Detailed sources for each variable and country are: (1) For the US: The Census Bureau and Current Population Survey. Income brackets (annual gross household income, in Dollars) are defined as: less than 20,000; 20,000–40,000; 40,000–70,000; more than 70,000. (2) For the UK: Eurostat Census Data and Office of National Statistics. Income brackets (monthly net household income, in Pounds) are: less than 1,500; 1,500–2,500; 2,500–3,000; more than 3,000. (3) For France: Eurostat Census Data and INSEE. Income brackets (monthly net household income, in Euros) are: less than 1,500; 1,500–2,500; 2,500–3,000; more than 3,000. (4) For Italy: Eurostat Census Data, Bank of Italy and ISTAT. Income brackets (monthly net household income, in Euros) are: less than 1,500; 1,500–2,450; 2,450–3,350; more than 3,350. (5) For Germany: Eurostat Census Data and GfK Demographics. Income brackets (monthly net household income, in Euros) are: less than 1,500; 1,500–2,600; 2,600–4,000; more than 4,000. (6) For Sweden: Eurostat Census Data and Statistics Sweden. Income brackets (monthly gross household income, in SEK) are: less than 33,000; 33,000–42,000; 42,000–58,000; more than 58,000. We count as employed both full-time and part-time workers. See [Supplementary Appendix Table A-5](#) for the equivalent statistics for the “raw” sample.

Table 1: sample characteristics

REVIEW OF ECONOMIC STUDIES

The pie chart below represents all the people currently living in the U.S. Out of all these people currently living in the U.S., how many do you think are legal immigrants? Move the slider to indicate how many out of every 100 people you think are legal immigrants.

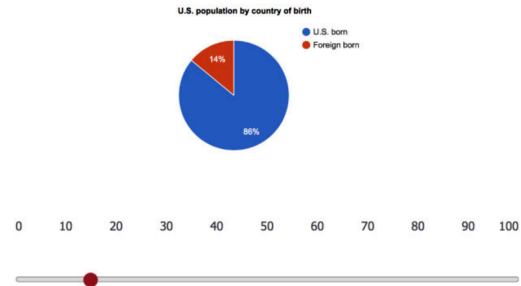


FIGURE 1
Eliciting perceptions on the share of immigrants

Figure 1: eliciting perceived immigrant share

6.2 Figures 2 and 3: misperceptions about immigrant shares and religion

Read:

- Figure 2 shows that all countries overestimate immigrant shares, with especially large errors in the U.S., Italy, Germany, and the UK.
- Right-wing respondents and respondents without immigrant parents tend to have larger errors, but misperceptions are broad-based.
- Figure 3 shows large overestimation of Muslim immigrants and underestimation of Christian immigrants.
- These religion errors are especially important because perceived cultural distance is politically salient.

Economic message: Respondents do not simply overcount immigrants. They also imagine immigrants as culturally more distant than they actually are.

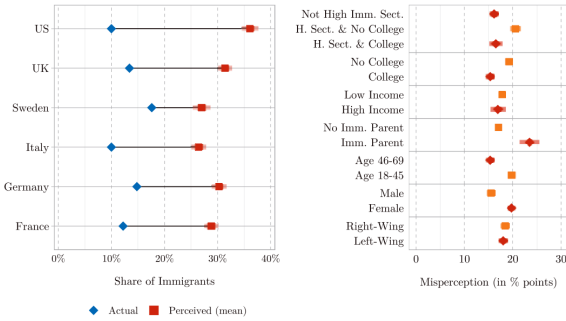


FIGURE 2
Perceived vs. actual share of immigrants

Notes: The left panel shows the average perceived share of immigrants (squares) and the actual share (diamonds) in each country. The right panel shows the average misperception (perceived minus actual share) of the share of immigrants by group. Groups are defined by

Figure 2: perceived vs actual immigrant share

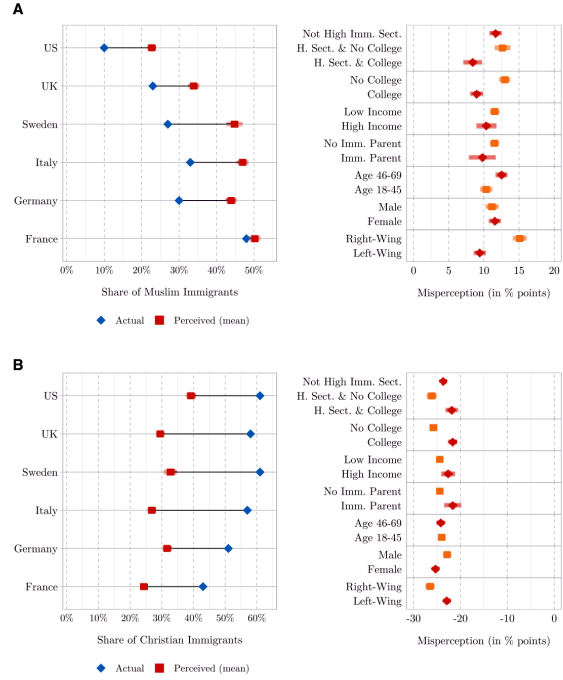


FIGURE 3
Perceived vs. actual religion of immigrants

Figure 3: perceived religion of immigrants

6.3 Figures 4 and 5: economic circumstances and work effort

Read:

- Figure 4 shows that respondents overestimate immigrant unemployment and poverty and underestimate immigrant education relative to the truth.
- The paper compares immigrant misperceptions to non-immigrant misperceptions, showing that immigrant beliefs are especially distorted.
- Figure 5 shows that many respondents attribute immigrant poverty or success to effort-related factors.
- Right-wing respondents are especially likely to hold negative beliefs about immigrant work effort.

Economic message: The economically important perception is not just that there are many immigrants, but that immigrants are thought to be poorer, less educated, less employed, and less deserving.

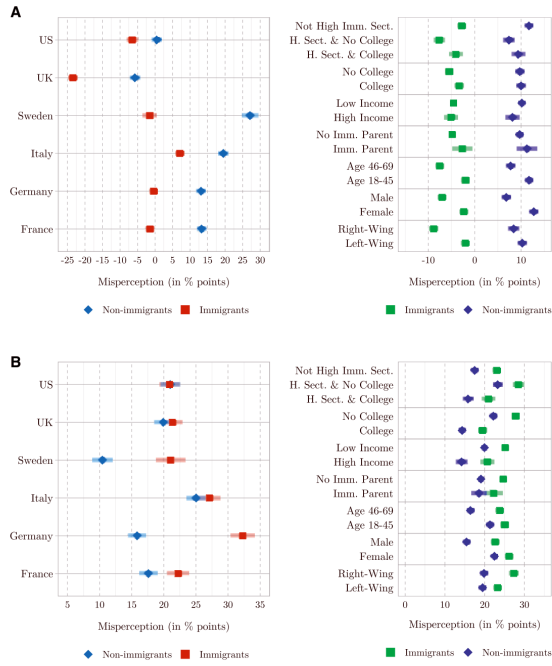


FIGURE 4

Misperception of immigrants' and non-immigrants' economic circumstances

Notes: (A) The left panel shows the average misperception (perceived - actual share) of the share of immigrant (squares) and non-immigrants (diamonds) with a college degree in each country; the right panel shows the average misperception of the share of immigrants (squares)

Figure 4: economic circumstance misperceptions

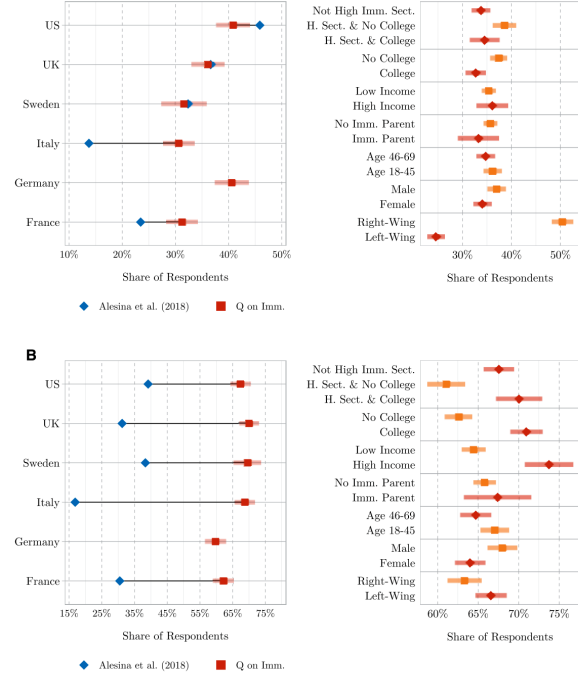


FIGURE 5

Views on immigrants' work effort

Notes: (A) This figure shows the share of respondents who think that immigrants who are poor are in that situation because of lack of effort, by country (left panel) and by group (right panel). (B) This figure shows the share of respondents who think that immigrants who are

Figure 5: views on immigrants' work effort

6.4 Figures 6 and 7: welfare use and poverty

Read:

- Figure 6 shows that many respondents believe immigrants receive more government transfers and benefit more from redistribution than comparable non-immigrants.
- Figure 7 shows that respondents overestimate poverty among both immigrants and non-immigrants, but immigrant poverty perceptions remain especially salient for redistribution views.

Economic message: Perceived welfare dependence is the key channel connecting immigration to lower redistribution support.

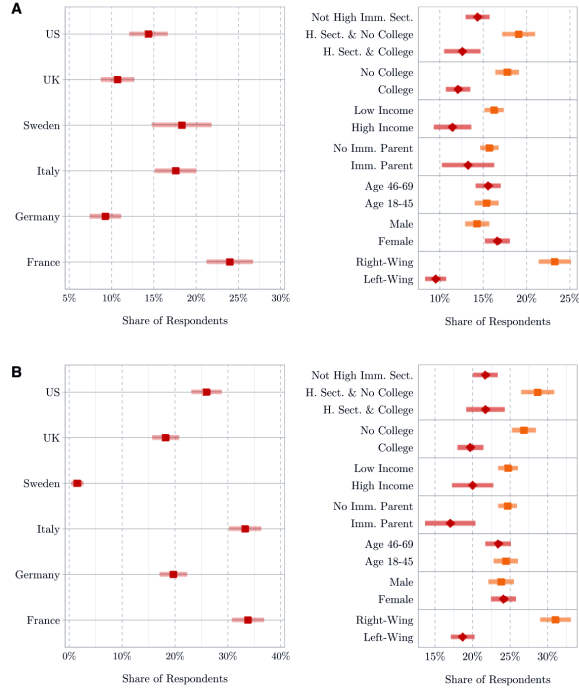


FIGURE 6

Figure 6: perceived redistribution benefits

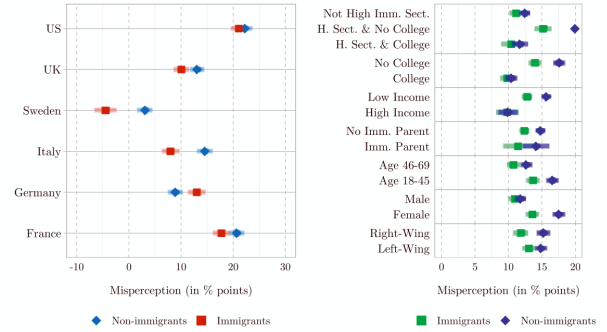


FIGURE 7

Misperception of poverty of immigrants and non-immigrants

Notes: This figure shows misperceptions of the share of immigrants and of non-immigrants who live in poverty. See notes for Figure 4.

Figure 7: poverty misperceptions

6.5 Figures 8 and 9: immigration attitudes and alternative definitions

Read:

- Figure 8 shows support for immigration policy statements by country and respondent group.
- Respondents differ strongly by ideology, education, and having an immigrant parent.
- Figure 9 compares perceived immigrant shares with first-generation and first-plus-second-generation definitions.
- The standard misperception result is not eliminated by using a broader definition of immigrants.

Economic message: Respondents' perceptions and attitudes are robust to definitional issues. The central problem is not merely disagreement over who counts as an immigrant.

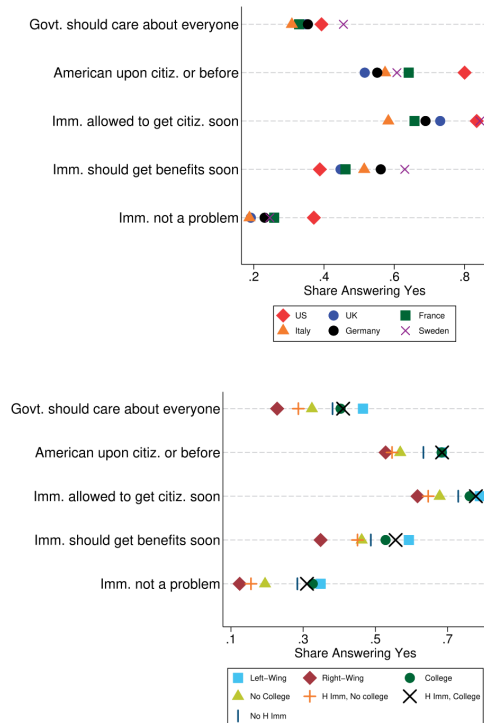


FIGURE 8

Support for immigration

Notes: This figure shows the share of respondents answering "Yes" to the questions listed on the vertical axis, by country (A) and respondent

Figure 8: support for immigration

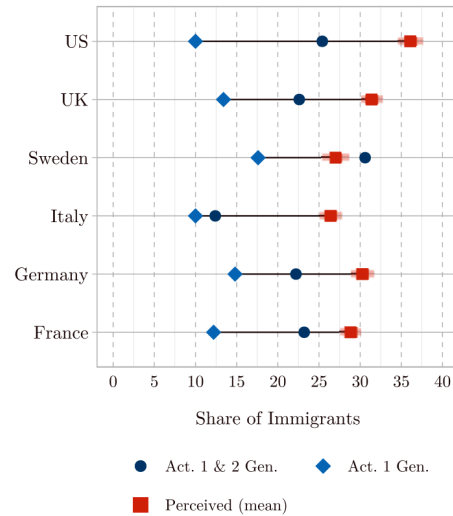


FIGURE 9

Perceived share of immigrants vs. actual share of first- and second-generation immigrants

Figure shows the average perceived share of first-generation immigrants (squares), the actual share of first-generation

Figure 9: first- and second-generation comparisons

6.6 Tables 2 and 3: origins of perceptions

Read:

- Table 2 relates perceptions to actual local immigrant shares and local immigrant characteristics.
- Local immigrant share is positively related to perceived immigrant share, but the coefficient is far from one.
- Respondent characteristics also matter: right-wing respondents, women, and lower-education respondents often have larger misperceptions.
- Table 3 shows that actual local and national immigrant characteristics are correlated with perceptions, but correlations are imperfect and often small.

Economic message: People learn somewhat from their environment, but local reality does not fully discipline beliefs. Narratives, ideology, and stereotypes remain important.

TABLE 2
Perceived vs. actual share, cultural distance, economic weakness, and free-riding of immigrants at the local level

	All immigrants (misp.) (1)	Perc. cultural distance index (2)	Perc. econ. weakness index (3)	Perc. free-riding index (4)
Local share of immigrants	0.203*** (0.0453)			
Actual local cultural distance index		0.0515*** (0.0147)		
Actual local economic circumstances index			0.0981*** (0.0296)	
Right-wing	0.895 (0.572)	0.0663*** (0.0233)	0.315*** (0.0275)	0.566*** (0.0278)
Female	4.143*** (0.567)	0.0108 (0.0223)	-0.0650** (0.0266)	0.0170 (0.0268)
Age 18-45	4.028*** (0.566)	-0.0181 (0.0223)	-0.0996*** (0.0267)	0.0299 (0.0269)
Immigrant parent	6.002*** (1.052)	0.0923*** (0.0338)	-0.112** (0.0456)	-0.0828** (0.0416)
Has a college degree	-4.219*** (0.747)	-0.0129 (0.0322)	-0.182*** (0.0380)	-0.236*** (0.0383)
High income	0.0586 (0.799)	0.00759 (0.0305)	-0.0480 (0.0360)	-0.118*** (0.0350)
H. Imm. Sect. no college	3.326*** (0.747)	0.000657 (0.0296)	0.116*** (0.0353)	0.0642* (0.0367)
H. Imm. Sect. college	1.766** (0.889)	-0.0390 (0.0348)	0.00703 (0.0420)	0.0832** (0.0394)
Observations	5047	5065	5065	5065
Control mean	17.67	0.00	0.00	0.00

Notes: Column (1) reports the correlation between the misperception of the share of immigrants (defined as the perceived share minus the actual national share) and the actual share of immigrants in the respondent's region (see [Supplementary Appendix A-1](#) for details). Columns (2)-(4) report the correlation between the perceived cultural distance, perceived economic weakness, and perceived free-riding indices and their actual equivalent in the respondent's region. We do not have the equivalent equivalent for the perceived free-riding index in the respondent's region. We do not have the equivalent equivalent for the perceived free-riding index in the respondent's region. We do not have the equivalent equivalent for the perceived free-riding index in the respondent's region.

Table 2: local-level determinants of perceptions

TABLE 3
Correlations between perceived and actual characteristics of immigrants and non-immigrants at the local and national levels

	Share of immigrants (1)	Imm. from Latin America (2)	Imm. from Africa (3)	Imm. from Asia (4)	Imm. from Europe (5)	Unemployment imm. (6)	No high school imm. (7)	College-educated imm. (8)	Poverty imm. (9)	Muslim imm. (10)
Panel A: Correlation of perceived immigrants' characteristics with actual immigrants' characteristics										
cal correlation	0.203*** (0.0453)	0.0859*** (0.0303)	0.155*** (0.0566)	0.139*** (0.0295)	0.155*** (0.0280)	0.585*** (0.147)	0.0718 (0.0545)	0.0600 (0.0457)		
tional correlation	-0.517*** (0.118)	0.478*** (0.0460)	0.517*** (0.0171)	0.376*** (0.0207)	0.268*** (0.0140)	1.054*** (0.0743)	0.725*** (0.0327)	0.324*** (0.0225)	0.333*** (0.0902)	0.786*** (0.0236)
Panel B: Correlation of perceived immigrants' characteristics with actual non-immigrants' characteristics										
cal correlation	0.090*** (0.132)	0.110 (0.0858)	0.0974** (0.0418)	0.440*** (0.0711)						
tional correlation	1.501*** (0.142)	0.486*** (0.0403)	0.440*** (0.0351)	0.0376 (0.132)						
Panel C: Correlation of perceived immigrants' characteristics with actual immigrants-non-immigrants differences										
cal correlation	-0.468*** (0.142)	0.0354 (0.0660)	-0.0413 (0.0433)							
tional correlation	1.287*** (0.106)	0.368*** (0.0443)	0.256*** (0.0477)	0.438*** (0.0582)						
Panel D: Correlation of perceived non-immigrants' characteristics with actual non-immigrants' characteristics										
cal correlation	0.782*** (0.104)	0.232*** (0.0821)	0.4692* (0.0419)	0.350*** (0.0641)						
tional correlation	1.941*** (0.112)	0.535*** (0.0386)	0.160*** (0.0384)	-0.462*** (0.112)						

Notes: Panel A reports the correlation between the perceptions of immigrants' characteristics listed in the columns and their actual equivalent at the commuting zone or regional level (local correlation) or at the national level ("National correlation"). Panel B reports the correlation between the perceptions of immigrants' characteristics listed in the columns and the actual corresponding characteristics for non-immigrants (at the local and national level). Since we do not have statistics on the poverty rate separately for immigrants and non-immigrants at the local level, in Column (6), we report the correlation with the local overall poverty rate. Panel C reports the correlation between the perceptions of immigrants' characteristics listed in the columns and the actual difference in that characteristic between immigrants and non-immigrants (at the local and national level). Panel D reports the correlation between the perceptions of non-immigrants' characteristics listed in the columns and their actual equivalent at the local or national level. The correlations are estimated in linear regressions including indicator variables listed in Table 2. Local level regressions also include country fixed effects. Robust standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Sample: respondents who have not seen any video treatment.

Table 3: correlations with actual immigrant characteristics

6.7 Table 4 and Figure 10: redistribution effects and mechanisms

Read:

- Table 4 shows that the order/salience treatment reduces support for redistribution.
- Making immigration salient lowers desired top-one-percent taxation, social spending, concern about inequality, and donations.
- Figure 10 shows that perceived economic weakness and free-riding are strongly correlated with lower support for redistribution.
- Perceived cultural distance is more related to support for immigration than to redistribution.

Economic message: The causal salience effect is negative, and the most relevant mechanism is economic deservingness rather than immigrant share alone.

TABLE 4
Treatment effects on support for redistribution

	Tax top 1 (1)	Tax bottom 50 (2)	Social budget (3)	Education budget (4)	Inequality serious problem (5)	Donation above median (6)
Order/salience T	-1.948*** (0.416)	0.914*** (0.276)	-0.543** (0.238)	0.439** (0.175)	-0.0280** (0.0132)	-0.0479*** (0.0138)
T: share of immigrants	-0.627 (0.419)	0.0449 (0.278)	-0.479** (0.233)	0.188 (0.172)	-0.00590 (0.0133)	-0.0165 (0.0140)
T: origin of immigrants	-0.0662 (0.425)	0.0322 (0.284)	-0.465* (0.239)	0.164 (0.173)	0.00626 (0.0132)	0.00208 (0.0140)
T: hard work	0.0772 (0.422)	-0.212 (0.279)	-0.0944 (0.235)	0.333** (0.170)	0.0158 (0.0132)	0.00910 (0.0139)
Observations	19,765	19,765	19,765	19,765	19,765	19,765
Control mean	37.12	10.94	29.53	16.00	0.59	0.47

Notes: This table reports the effects of the *Order* treatment and the three video treatments on the variables in the columns. Outcome variables are described in [Supplementary Appendix A-1](#). Social and education budget are winsorized at the 5th and 95th percentile by country. Controls included in all regressions are: indicator variables for gender, age less than 45, having children, being in the top quartile of the income distribution, having a college degree, political affiliation, having at least one parent not born in the country, working in a high immigration sector, and country fixed effects. The regressions also include the interactions between the *Order* treatment and the three other treatments, not reported. Hence, the effect of the *Order* treatment is estimated only on respondents who have not seen any of the video treatments, and the effect of each video treatment is estimated only on respondents who have not seen the immigration block before the redistribution block. This implies that each treatment effect is effectively estimated on about 5200 observations, equally split between treatment and control. Robust standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

5% of the control group mean and 11% of the gap between left- and right-wing respondents.²³

Table 4: treatment effects on support for redistribution

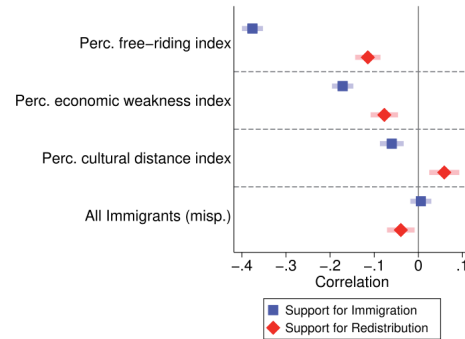


FIGURE 10

What drives support for immigration and redistribution?

Figure shows the correlation between the variables listed on the left and the immigration support index (sc 1 support index (diamonds). Indices are defined following the methodology in [Kling et al. \(2007\)](#) (see [S.1](#) for more details). Each set of correlations is estimated in a regression including all the variables listed on the left and the corresponding control variables—indicator variables for gender, age less than 45, having children, being in the top quartile of the income distribution, having a college degree, political affiliation, having at least one parent not born in the country, working in a high immigration sector, and country fixed effects.

Figure 10: what drives support for immigration and redistribution

6.8 Figure 11, Table 5, and Table 6: video treatments

Read:

- Figure 11 shows screenshots from the three video treatments: immigrant share, origins, and hard work.

- Table 5 reports first-stage effects on perceptions. The share treatment reduces misperception of immigrant share. The origins treatment shifts origin and religion beliefs. The hard-work treatment affects beliefs about work effort.
- Table 6 reports effects on support for immigration. The hard-work treatment raises the immigration support index more than the factual treatments.
- However, these treatments do not fully undo the negative effect of making immigration salient.

Economic message: Facts can correct specific factual beliefs, but narrative information is more powerful for deservingness beliefs. Even so, immigration salience remains difficult to overcome.

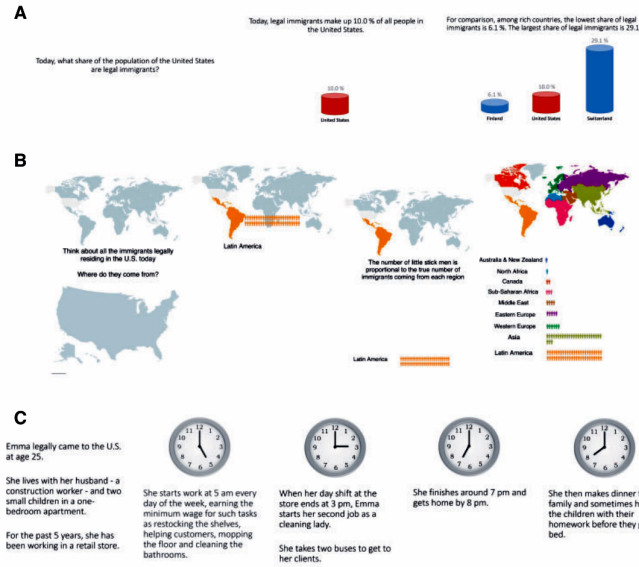


TABLE 5
First-stage treatment effects on perceptions

	All immigrants (misp.) (1)	Accurate perception all immigrants (2)	M. East and N. Africa (misp.) (3)	N. America, W. and E. Europe (misp.) (4)	Muslim (misp.) (5)	Christian (misp.) (6)	Lack of effort reason poor (7)
T: share of immigrants	-4.864*** (0.411)	0.227*** (0.00691)	-0.248 (0.313)	0.173 (0.357)	0.00857 (0.419)	0.144 (0.397)	0.000297 (0.00921)
T: origin of immigrants	2.315*** (0.426)	0.00251 (0.00411)	-4.794*** (0.295)	1.827*** (0.356)	-1.829*** (0.405)	2.456*** (0.397)	-0.000234 (0.00925)
T: hard work	0.709* (0.409)	-0.00420 (0.00396)	-0.385 (0.308)	0.378 (0.352)	-0.869** (0.404)	0.796** (0.393)	-0.0535*** (0.00899)
Observations	19,735	19,735	19,747	19,728	19,761	19,757	19,721
Control mean	17.02	0.04	12.60	-5.56	11.30	-23.98	0.36

Notes: This table reports the first-stage effects of the three video treatments on (mis)perceptions of immigrants. Misperceptions are computed as perception minus actual statistic. *Accurate perception all immigrants* is a dummy equal to 1 if the absolute value of the respondent's misperception of the share of immigrants is less than 1. [Supplementary Appendix A-1](#) defines all variables. All regressions include the same controls as Table 4. Robust standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

Table 5: first-stage treatment effects on perceptions

TABLE 6
Treatment effects on support for immigration

	Imm. not a problem (1)	Imm. benefits soon (2)	Imm. citizenship upon citizenship/before (3)	American about everyone (4)	Govt. should care (5)	Imm support index (6)
T: share of immigrants	0.0242*** (0.00825)	0.00991 (0.00959)	0.0158* (0.00857)	0.00508 (0.00936)	-0.00395 (0.0359)	0.0364*** (0.0181)
T: origin of immigrants	0.00527 (0.00822)	0.00360 (0.00961)	0.000649 (0.00863)	0.00448 (0.00937)	-0.00222 (0.0361)	0.00877 (0.0182)
T: hard work	0.0252*** (0.00829)	0.0202** (0.00957)	0.0133 (0.00857)	0.0171* (0.00934)	0.131*** (0.0359)	0.0708*** (0.0181)
Observations	19,727	19,749	19,745	19,742	19,754	19,765
Control mean	0.25	0.49	0.71	0.62	4.53	0.00

Notes: This table reports the effects of the three video treatments on the variables in the columns. Outcome variables are described in [Supplementary Appendix A-1](#). The immigration support index is constructed following the methodology in [Kling et al. \(2007\)](#), as explained in [Supplementary Appendix A-1](#). All regressions include the same controls as Table 4. Robust standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 6: treatment effects on support for immigration

7 Short summary

- The paper studies how perceptions of immigration affect support for redistribution.
- It uses surveys and experiments in six countries with roughly 24,000 respondents.
- Respondents overestimate immigrant shares and misperceive immigrant composition.
- They view immigrants as more culturally distant, more economically weak, more unemployed, poorer, and more welfare-dependent than they are.
- These beliefs persist despite accuracy incentives and are stronger among some demographic and political groups.
- Making immigration salient reduces support for redistribution and charitable donations.

- Perceived economic weakness and welfare dependence are the most important perception channels for redistribution preferences.
- Factual information about shares and origins changes some beliefs but has limited effects on redistribution support.
- A hard-working immigrant narrative has stronger effects on some attitudes, suggesting that narratives may matter more than hard facts.
- The paper’s incremental contribution is to connect misperceptions, narratives, and redistribution preferences in a large cross-country experimental design.

8 Conclusion

8.1 Core conclusion

Alesina, Miano, and Stantcheva show that immigration can reduce support for redistribution because people hold systematically distorted beliefs about immigrants. These distortions are not limited to immigrant numbers: respondents also misperceive immigrants’ economic position, cultural distance, welfare use, and work effort.

8.2 Economic intuition

Redistribution support depends on who voters think benefits from redistribution. If voters believe that immigrants are numerous, economically weak, and more likely to free-ride on welfare, they become less willing to support redistributive policies. The paper shows that these beliefs can be activated simply by making immigration salient.

8.3 Incremental contribution takeaway

The paper’s main incremental contribution is to show that the immigration-redistribution link runs through detailed perceptions and narratives, not just through objective immigrant shares. It also shows that correcting hard facts is not enough when stereotypes and deservingness narratives are deeply embedded.

8.4 Takeaway

The policy implication is that redistribution politics cannot be separated from immigration narratives. Governments and policymakers who want to sustain support for redistribution in diverse societies must address not only factual misinformation about immigration levels, but also beliefs about work effort, deservingness, and fiscal contribution.